

Neighborhood Oral History Handbook -- Mini

Cover Blurp

This short handbook is a born-digital smoke fixture for the maintained book-like PDF lane. It models a compact table-of-contents booklet with front matter, short procedural chapters, and a closing checklist.

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Preparing the interview kit

Start with a simple paper folder for each narrator. Put the consent form on top, the prompt sheet behind it, and the spare batteries in a labelled pouch. Do not trust memory at the table: write the date, neighborhood, and recorder serial number before you begin.

Bring two pencils, not one. A volunteer who stops the conversation to search for a pen changes the rhythm of the interview. The goal of the kit is not to look impressive; it is to make the first five minutes feel boring and steady.

Running the session

Open with the shortest possible framing sentence. Ask the narrator to say their name, then wait. If they pause, do not rush to fill the silence. The first useful detail often arrives after the second breath, not the first.

Use follow-up questions that anchor the speaker in place and time. "What could you hear from the porch?" is better than "What was it like?" because it yields details that later readers can verify and tag. If a person drifts, mark the timecode quietly and circle back after the main thread finishes.

Logging the archive copy

When the session ends, copy the recording immediately and make the filenames boringly literal: year, month, day, narrator surname, interviewer surname.

Write the same string on the folder tab. If the title differs between the audio file, the folder, and the spreadsheet, cleanup work multiplies for no gain.

Add a three-line note before you leave the site: what worked, what confused the narrator, and which names or locations still need spelling confirmation.

Those notes are small, but they prevent the next volunteer from repeating the same uncertainty.

Publishing notes

Before publishing an excerpt, check that the pull quote still makes sense once the surrounding warm-up lines are gone. A transcript can be accurate and still mislead if the scene-setting sentence was trimmed away.

Close every packet with the same checklist: confirm consent, confirm spelling, confirm the storage path, confirm the public note. Repeatable close-out is not glamorous, but it keeps the archive trustworthy.